

BANDEEP SINGH

LITERARY LEGACY The three-volume collector's edition of a *A Suitable Boy*, published by Speaking Tiger

A SUITABLE BOY
by Vikram Seth
SPEAKING TIGER
₹1,799; 1,584 pages

Q.

Of all your many books, *A Suitable Boy* is certainly among those that have endured in the reading imagination. What would you attribute its timeless appeal to—the plot, the characters, the sheer sweep of the story, the fact that it is the great Indian novel?
Let's leave 'timeless' and 'great' out of this. *A Suitable Boy* will have to endure for a good deal longer than 30 years to merit that. But, yes, the book has remained popular—far longer than I expected. I think (at least from what readers tell me) that it's the characters who do it, especially the affectionate but all-encompassing Mrs Rupa Mehra, who was based on my own Nani, one of the three dedicatees of the book (the other two are my parents).

As for the effect on readers of the 'sweep of the story', one reader told me that at the end of the book, she flung it across the room in annoyance. And another that it made her propose at once to her somewhat timid boyfriend.

Q. Did you feel audacious writing such a big book and, indeed, did you set out consciously to do so?
It evolved. I had no intention of writing such a tome when I began. My publishers in India were Penguin. David Davidar, though perhaps alarmed by the length of the book, encouraged me hugely, read the first draft, and made very useful suggestions. Because the typesetting was going slowly, I decided one morning to camp in his flat for a month to ensure that it got done. He was too shocked to demur.

I didn't have any publishers abroad at the time, so it was put up for auction, and all nine publishers in the UK to whom it was offered bid for it. That was (I thought) courageous of them, since it was an expensive book to produce, very long to have to read and review, and threatened to take up quite a lot of shelf-width in bookshops. Besides, why would the British be interested in an obscure period of post-Raj India? Orion, which was a new publisher at the time, were the winners of the auction. The book did well, and they were rewarded for their rashness.

Q. *A Suitable Boy* was published 30 years ago, but it was 10 years in the making before that. Did you have the plot figured out before you sat down to write it?
It's an iterative process—a bit structured, a bit erratic. There's some shaping, of course, but if it appears too obvious, the whole thing wouldn't ring true. I had an idea or two at the start, but the plot was far from figured out. And if the characters weren't unruly and independent, I wouldn't have enjoyed writing it.

Q. You've experimented with a variety of genres. Is it a way to challenge yourself? And are you partial to a particular genre?
It wasn't that I wanted to challenge myself. It's just that if a story or an inspiration suited a particular genre, I didn't mind trying it, even if for the first time.

"*A SUITABLE GIRL* IS CERTAINLY ON ITS WAY, BUT AT A TIME OF HER CHOOSING," SAYS VIKRAM SETH

The worst that could happen was that I'd fail—and I didn't see that as a disaster.

Yes to your second question. It is poetry that I love most of all. I stumbled into writing novels through my book *The Golden Gate*, which was both a novel and a poem. Poetry was the first thing I wrote and will, I hope, be the last.

Q. All talk these days is of shrinking attention spans. Can the contemporary reader handle a book the size of A Suitable Boy?
I hope so. Fat though it is, it consists of bite-sized chapters. And, given Speaking Tiger's edition (divided into three volumes—and resplendent in gold and turquoise!), one won't even have to sprain one's wrists.

Q. *A Suitable Boy* also addresses contemporaneous concerns. Some of those issues are as relevant today. Hindu-Muslim polarisation comes to mind. Have we as a nation not moved forward at all? And, is there hope for the idea of India?
Issues like zamindari and the state of the countryside, the position of women, the first general election, small town and university life, etc., do enter the book; but this wasn't in order to 'address' them as such, but rather because they were concerns of or obsessions of or contexts for one character or another.

As for Hindu-Muslim polarisation, we have gone backwards. There has been a deliberate attempt, often for electoral advantage, to inject grievance, victimhood and hatred into our hearts, and to make our fellow citizens feel like outsiders in their own home. I consider this unpatriotic, un-Indian and, indeed, un-Hindu. It will take a generation to